

How to Watch a Broadcast Like You Mean It

What the TV camera hides, what the replays and the All-22 give back, the five-second read before every snap, your first tells, and the prediction log you'll keep for the rest of the course.

Third-and-6, early in the fourth quarter. The broadcast shows you the quarterback barking at his line, cuts to a tight shot of the center's hands, and the ball is snapped. For two seconds you watch linemen shove each other. Then the camera whips upfield and a receiver who was not on your screen a moment ago catches the ball thirty yards downfield, with a safety you never saw arriving a step too late. The analyst says, "The safety bit on the play fake, and that's the easiest throw he'll make all day." Which safety? Bit on what? You were watching the whole time, and you didn't see any of it. That is not your fault. A broadcast is built to show you the ball, and most of what decides a play happens away from it. This chapter is about watching around the broadcast: what the camera leaves out, where the other angles come in, what to read in the few seconds before the snap, and how to keep score of your own guesses so that, by the end of this course, you can tell whether you are actually getting better at reading the game.

You'll be able to...

- Say what the main TV camera hides (usually the safeties and the outside receivers) and which replay angle (end zone, skycam, the wide All-22) gives back each missing piece.
- Use the pause before each snap to read down, distance, field position, score, clock and timeouts from the scorebug in under five seconds, and turn them into a run-or-pass lean.
- Pick *one thing* to watch on each snap and on each replay, chosen by the situation, instead of following the ball.
- Read the win-probability bar and the Next Gen Stats numbers a broadcast puts on screen as plain-English estimates (the models behind them come later).
- Spot four starter tells (the linemen's stance, the running back's depth and offset, receiver splits, safety depth) and treat each as a clue that shifts the odds, not a promise.
- Keep a prediction log on paper or in ten lines of pandas, score it, and compare it with what the down and distance alone would have earned you.

The camera is built for the ball

Almost everything you have ever seen of an NFL game came through one camera. The **sideline camera** is the broadcast's main camera: it sits high on one side of the stadium, usually near the 50-yard line on the press-box side, and it follows the ball. Before the snap the director frames the formation fairly tightly, so the quarterback, the linemen and the players near them fill the screen. At the snap the operator keeps the ball in the middle of the picture, and when the ball is thrown he swings with it.

That is the right choice for television. The ball is the story, the faces are the drama, and a tight shot reads well on a phone. The cost is everything else. Here is roughly what a typical pre-snap shot covers, drawn from above:

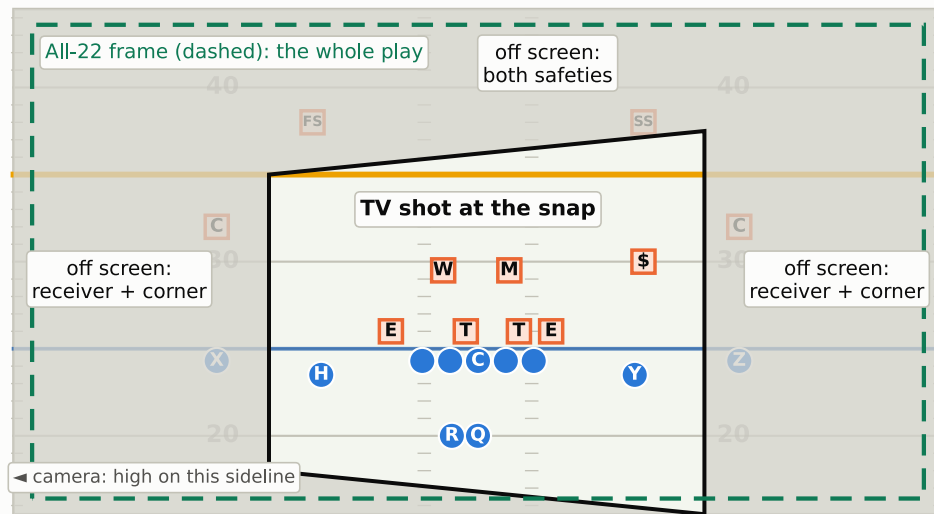
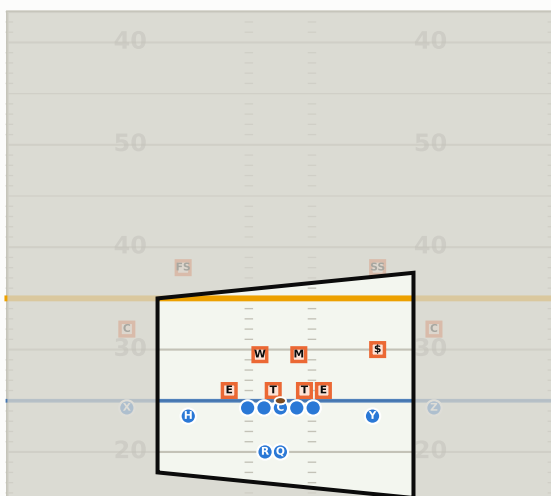


Figure 1: What a typical pre-snap TV shot shows, drawn from above. The broadcast camera is high on the left sideline (the offense's left), so the area it sees on the ground is a trapezoid: narrow on the near side, wider on the far side. Everything shaded grey is off your screen at the snap. In this ordinary formation that is six of the 22 players, and they are the six that decide most passes: both safeties, both outside receivers and the two cornerbacks covering them. The dashed outline is what the All-22 camera keeps in view for the entire play: everyone. (Illustrative; directors frame shots differently, and some go wider.)

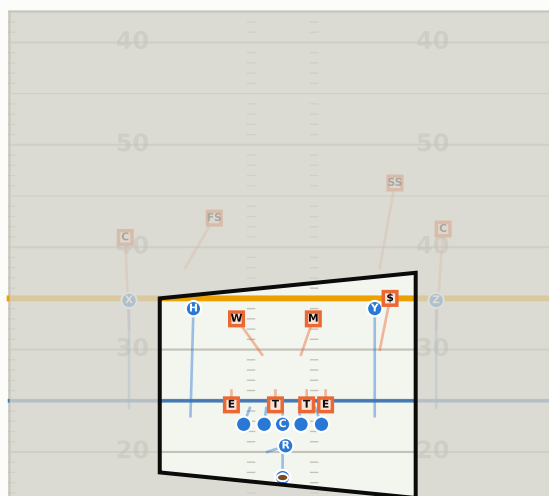
Count what made the screen: the five linemen, the quarterback, the running back, the two inside receivers, the four defensive linemen, two linebackers and the slot defender. Sixteen players. The six you can't see are the two **safeties** (the deepest defenders, usually 10 to 15 yards off the ball; see The Twenty-Two), the two wide receivers split out near the sidelines, and the two **cornerbacks** covering them. If you want to know whether a pass will work, those are exactly the six you most want to see. The safeties tell you how the defense is covering the deep part of the field; the outside receivers and corners are where most long throws go.

It gets worse after the snap, because the camera chases the ball. Watch the same thing play out over four seconds:

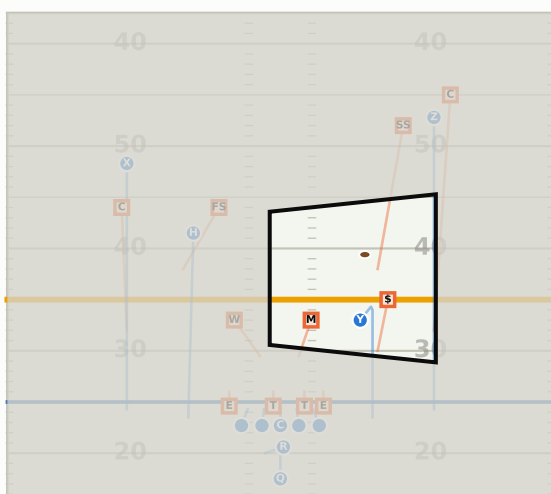
1 Before the snap: the formation



2 Protection and rush (+1.4 s)



3 Ball in the air: camera pans



4 The catch: 3 of 22 on screen

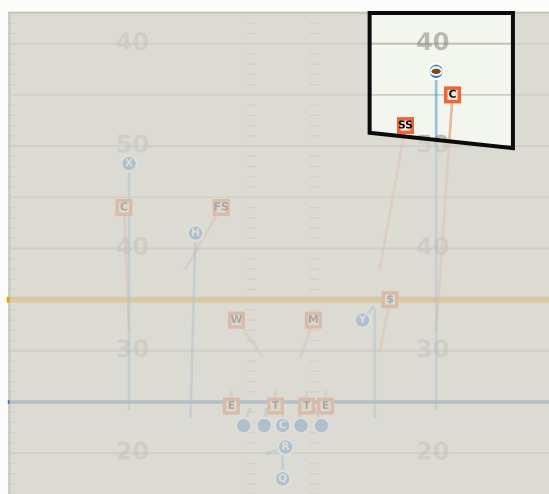


Figure 2: The camera follows the ball (simulated play; the grey is what is off your screen). Before the snap and for the first two seconds the shot stays on the formation, so you see the pass protection and the rush but not the two deep safeties drifting back or the receiver on the far sideline running past his cornerback. When the ball is thrown the camera pans with it and tightens on the catch: by then you can see three players, and the other nineteen, including the safety who was supposed to be there, are gone.

The replays exist to show you the grey.

This is why the analyst in the opening couldn't see what you couldn't. He had a monitor with a wider angle, or he had already seen the replay. On the live shot, the defense's whole back half is a rumor until the ball arrives.

! Why it exists: a picture made for the ball

Why don't networks just show the wide shot? Because the broadcast is made for a much larger audience than the people who want to study coverage. A wide shot makes the players tiny, and the things most viewers care about (who has the ball, the hit, the catch, the celebration) get lost in it. So the main camera trades *context* for *clarity*: it shows you the ball clearly and the structure of the play hardly at all. The good news is that the broadcast also shows the same play three or four more times, from other angles, a few seconds later. The skill is to use those replays on purpose.

The other angles: replays, the end zone and the skycam

Between plays, the director cuts to replays. On an ordinary play you might get one; on a big play you'll typically get a short sequence, and each angle answers a different question:

1. **Live, from the sideline camera.** The ball, framed tightly.

2. **A tight replay on the key player**, often from a handheld camera at field level: the catch, the hit, the run. Great for drama, useless for structure.
3. **The end zone**. The **end-zone camera** sits behind one end zone and looks straight down the field. It is the best angle there is for the line: which linemen moved forward and which backward, where the gaps opened, which defender the running back cut off. Coaches film includes a high version of it.
4. **The skycam**. The **skycam** is a camera hung from cables above the field that can fly anywhere over it. On replays it usually sits a few yards behind the offense, roughly where the quarterback's eyes are, and shows the defense the way he saw it: where the safeties went at the snap, who dropped into coverage, which receiver came open.
5. **Super slow motion** on the catch or the tackle, especially if a review is possible.

Directors vary the order and the mix, and some games use the skycam as a live angle for a few plays. But the logic is constant: the live shot follows the ball, and the replays fill in the rest, if you know which question each one answers.

Table 1: Which angle answers which question. The first four come with the broadcast; the last comes with coaches film.

Angle	Best for	Watch this
Sideline (live)	The ball; the pass rush; who has the ball at the end	The pocket, the run's first few yards
Tight / handheld	Catches, hits, the runner's feet	Hands and feet on close calls
End zone	The line, gaps and running lanes	Did the linemen go forward (run) or back (pass)? Where did the hole open?
Skycam	Coverage and the quarterback's view	The two safeties' first steps; who was open, and when
All-22 (wide)	Everything, all at once	Any player you didn't watch the first time

The skycam has a nice history of being too early. It was invented by Garrett Brown, the cameraman-engineer who had already invented the Steadicam, and first used at an NFL preseason game between the Chargers and the 49ers in San Diego in August 1984. It then mostly gathered dust: it was expensive to fly, and the computers and motors of the day made it slow and finicky. It became a regular part of NFL broadcasts only after the XFL leaned on it heavily in 2001.¹ That story repeats across broadcast technology. The yellow first-down line that every viewer now takes for granted was first shown on ESPN's broadcast of a Bengals–Ravens game on September 27, 1998, after one network agreed to pay for it.² (On the field there is no yellow line; it is painted onto the picture by computer, which is why players walk “through” it.)

¹Sports Broadcasting Hall of Fame, “Garrett Brown” (inventor of the Steadicam and Skycam): <https://www.sportsbroadcastinghalloffame.org/inductees/garrett-brown/> ; “Skycam,” *Wikipedia* (first public use in fall 1984 at an NFL preseason game in San Diego between the Chargers and 49ers, televised by CBS; little used until the XFL in 2001, then by ESPN on NFL preseason games in 2001 and Sunday Night Football from 2002): <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Skycam> ; contemporary account: *Inc.*, “‘Goalpost’ Brown’s Amazing Flying Camera” (January 1985), on the August 1984 CBS telecast of the 49ers’ preseason game in San Diego, with Pat Summerall introducing “something we call Skycam”: <https://www.inc.com/magazine/19850101/4162.html>

²*Sports Illustrated*, “The story behind football’s innovative yellow first down line” (July 18, 2013): <https://www.si.com/nfl/2013/07/18/nfl-birth-yellow-line> ; “1st & Ten (graphics system),” *Wikipedia* (first aired by Sportvision on ESPN’s Bengals–Ravens broadcast, September 27, 1998): [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/1st_%26_Ten_\(graphics_system\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/1st_%26_Ten_(graphics_system))

³*Sportico*, “Amazon adds ‘Prime Vision’ feed to Thursday Night Football” (2022): <https://www.sportico.com/business/media/2022/amazon-prime-vision-thursday-night-football-feed-1234691348/> ; *The Ringer* (Dec. 14, 2023), on the alternate broadcast’s higher in-play camera and live route tracing: <https://www.theringer.com/nfl/2023/12/14/24000808/amazon-prime-vision-alternate-nfl-broadcast-staying-power-revolution>

⁴*Philadelphia Inquirer*, “Thursday Night Football will use artificial intelligence” (Sept. 13, 2023), on Defensive Alerts identifying likely pass rushers from pre-snap movement: <https://www.inquirer.com/eagles/thursday-night-football-artificial-intelligence-eagles-vikings-20230913.html> ; Amazon, “Prime Video’s Thursday Night Football AI features” (feature list including Defensive Alerts, Coverage ID, Pressure Alert and Prime Targets): <https://aboutamazon.com/news/entertainment/thursday-night-football-amazon-prime-video-ai-features> ; *Sportico* (2024), on Coverage ID calling man or zone in

Film room: Prime Vision on Amazon's Thursday Night Football (2022–)

The closest thing to watching like a coach *live* is an alternate stream. When Amazon took over *Thursday Night Football* in 2022 it added a second feed, *Prime Vision with Next Gen Stats*, which uses a higher, wider camera during each play, so every player stays in view, and draws the receivers' routes as they run.³ In 2023 it added "Defensive Alerts," which uses the players' pre-snap movement to mark the defenders most likely to rush the quarterback, a computer doing the blitz-spotting you will learn to do by eye in *A First Look at Defense*.⁴ Later seasons added features such as coverage identification (man or zone, called in real time), also computed from player tracking (the data source is explained below).

What to notice if you try it: how much more of the defense you can see during the play, and how often the defenders it marks as likely rushers are *not* the ones who rush. The model is reading the same kind of clues you are about to learn, and it is right more often than not, not every time. Alternate streams come and go by season and by network; if one is offered for a game you're watching, it is worth a quarter of your time.

All-22: the coaches' view

Coaches don't study the broadcast. They study **coaches film**: every snap shown twice, once from a high, wide sideline camera and once from a high end-zone camera, with no replays, no close-ups and no graphics. The sideline half of it is the **All-22**, named for the one thing it promises: the camera is zoomed out far enough that all 22 players stay in the frame from the snap until the whistle. It looks dull on first viewing (tiny players, no drama), and it is the single most useful football picture there is.

For decades it was available only to teams and a few media analysts. In 2012 the NFL began selling coaches film to fans, both the "All-22" and the "High End Zone" views, through its Game Rewind service.⁵ Today it comes with the league's NFL+ Premium subscription, which still offers it for the 2026 season; when the league described the package in 2024, the archive went back to the 2022 season.⁶ Some teams' own sites and several film-breakdown writers post All-22 clips too. You don't need it for this chapter, but if you ever want to settle a question the broadcast can't answer ("was the receiver open?"), that is where you go. Film Study: All-22, Charting a Game, and Scoring Yourself builds a full film-study routine around it.

Madden vs. real life

Here is an odd fact: *Madden* gives you a better view of football than the TV does. The game's default camera sits high behind the offense and shows all eleven defenders, which is closer to the skycam or the All-22 than to anything on a broadcast. That is part of why a game-literate viewer can find real broadcasts confusing: in *Madden* you always know where the safeties are, and on television you almost never do until the replay. If you want the *Madden* picture of a real play, you need coaches film or the skycam replay.

Common misconception

"If I watch closely enough, I'll see the play." On the live broadcast, mostly you won't, and nobody else watching it does either. The pros who seem to see everything live have usually seen the replay, the All-22 or the wider monitor in the booth. Your aim on the live shot is narrower: read the situation and the formation before the snap, watch one thing during the play, and use the replays for the rest.

real time from live player-tracking data: <https://www.sportico.com/business/media/2024/amazon-thursday-night-football-artificial-intelligence-features-price-1234796718>

⁵Buffalo Bills, "Watch film like a coach with Game Rewind" (July 30, 2012), on NFL.com's Game Rewind and Game Pass adding coaches film with the "All-22" and "High End Zone" views for every 2012 game: <https://www.buffalobills.com/news/watch-film-like-a-coach-with-game-rewind-7721721> ; *SportsBusiness Daily* (June 18, 2012): <https://www.sportsbusinessdaily.com/Daily/Issues/2012/06/18/Media/NFL-22.aspx>

⁶NFL.com, "Launch of NFL Pro highlights third season of NFL+" (2024): NFL+ Premium includes "All-22 Coaches Film for every NFL game dating back to the 2022 season": <https://www.nfl.com/news/launch-of-nfl-pro-highlights-third-season-of-nfl> ; Disney+ explainer on NFL+ Premium (Dec. 12, 2025), listing "the All-22 Coaches film" among Premium's features and offering Premium as an add-on to the Disney+/Hulu/ESPN bundle: <https://www.disneyplus.com/explore/articles/nfl-premium-prices-features> . Subscription packages change often; check before you buy.

The pre-snap pause: five things in five seconds

Every play has a pause. The offense breaks the huddle (or turns to look at the sideline, if it doesn't huddle; see What a Play Really Is), walks to the line, and gets set. From the moment they are set to the snap there are usually a few seconds, during which the broadcast shows the formation and the scorebug. That pause is the most valuable time you have as a viewer, because it is the last moment you can make a guess that counts. Spend the first part of it on the scorebug.

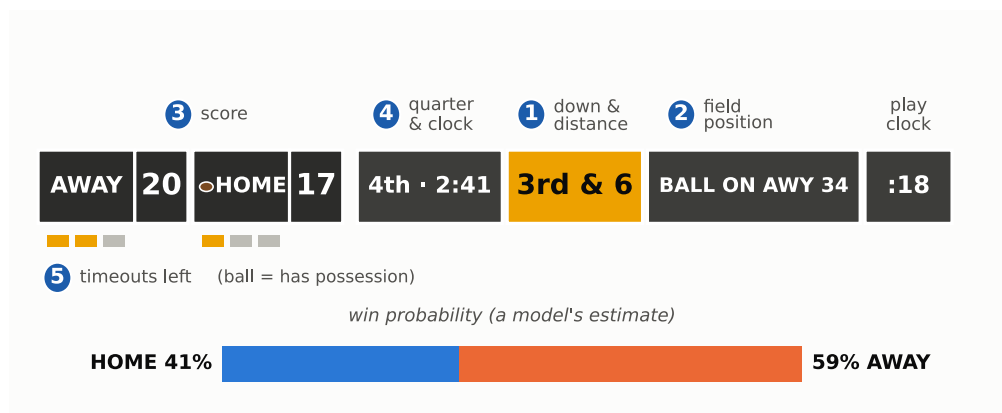


Figure 3: An illustrative scorebug (every network's design differs, and not all show field position). Read it in a fixed order: (1) down and distance, (2) where the ball is, (3) the score, (4) the clock, (5) the timeouts. Here the home team has the ball, trails by 3 with 2:41 left in the game, and faces third-and-6 at the opponent's 34 with one timeout. Below it, the win-probability bar some broadcasts add: a model's estimate, not a verdict.

Read it in the same order every time, and ask one question of each item:

1. **Down and distance** (Downs, Distance, and Field Position): *How many yards do they need, and how many tries do they have?* Bucket it: short (1–3 yards), medium (4–6), long (7 or more). This is the single biggest input to a run-or-pass guess. In the 2025 regular season, teams passed on about nine in ten third-and-medium snaps and on fewer than one in four third-and-1s.⁷
2. **Field position:** *Where are they?* Backed up near their own goal line, offenses play it safe; inside the opponent's 20 (the red zone) the field shrinks and the playbook changes; around the opponent's 35 a field goal becomes possible, which changes what fourth down means.
3. **Score:** *Who needs what?* A team behind by two scores late has to pass. A team ahead wants to run and keep the clock moving.
4. **Clock:** *How much time, and is it running?* (The clock rules are in The Game in Fifteen Minutes.) Inside the last two minutes of a half, everything tilts toward passes and the sideline. In 2025, teams trailing by one score in the last two minutes of the fourth quarter passed on 87% of snaps.⁸
5. **Timeouts:** *Can they stop the clock?* A trailing team with no timeouts can't afford a run that ends in bounds; a team with three can.

Put it together for the example. Third-and-6 is medium on third down, a passing down almost every time. The ball is at the opponent's 34, so a long field goal (about 51 yards: 34 to the goal line, about seven more back to the holder, and ten for the end zone) is the fallback if the pass fails, which makes a short, safe completion attractive. Down three with 2:41 left and one timeout, they need points, but they don't need a touchdown, and they can't waste a down. Your lean: **pass**, probably short to medium, to someone near the first-down marker. That took longer to write than it should take to think. With a few weeks of practice it becomes a glance.

Glossed numbers: the win-probability bar and Next Gen Stats

Broadcasts now put model outputs on screen. You don't need the models yet, but you do need to know what the numbers *mean*, so here is a plain-English reading of the common ones. Each is built properly later.

- **Win probability** (the bar under the scorebug above). An estimate of how often teams in exactly this situation (score, time left, field position, down and distance, timeouts) have gone on to win, based on many past seasons of games. "41%" means "teams in this spot win about four times in ten." It is not a judgment about these two teams, and it swings on every big play because the situation swings. The models are built in Win Probability and Decision Analysis.

⁷Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, 2025 regular season, runs and dropbacks (passes, sacks and scrambles counted as passes): third-and-4 to -6, 91% pass (1,652 snaps); third-and-1, 23% pass (853 snaps).

⁸Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, 2025 regular season: snaps in the last two minutes of the fourth quarter by teams trailing by 1 to 8 points, 87% pass (680 snaps; overtime excluded).

- **Next Gen Stats overlays.** Every player wears small radio chips in his shoulder pads, and receivers around the stadium record where each one is about ten times a second.⁹ The league turns those positions into numbers that broadcasts quote:
 - **Speed** (“he hit 21.4 miles per hour”): the ball carrier’s top speed on the play. Fun, and mostly about the open field he had, not just how fast he is.
 - **Completion probability** (“a 23% throw”): how often a pass with this distance, this receiver separation and this pressure is completed, judged from thousands of past throws. A low number on a completion means a hard throw and catch; a high number on an incompletion means an easy one missed.
 - **Separation:** the gap, in yards, between the receiver and the nearest defender when the ball arrives (the catch or the incompletion). The typical regular receiver averages about three yards over a season; a yard or less is tight coverage.¹⁰
 - **Time to throw:** seconds from the snap to the throw. The typical NFL pass is out in about two and a half seconds,¹¹ which is why everything you want to see before the throw has to happen fast.
 - **Expected rushing yards:** how far an average runner would have gained from the spot where the runner took the handoff, given where the blockers and defenders were; the difference is rush yards over expected.

How tracking data is collected, what it can and can’t measure, and how to work with it yourself is in Tracking Data and the Big Data Bowl.

Common misconception

“The bar said 90% and they lost, so the model was wrong.” A 90% estimate is supposed to be wrong about one time in ten. The fair test of a probability is whether, across many games where it said 90%, the team won about 90% of them. That idea, called calibration, is how you will score your own predictions at the end of the course.

Watch one thing

The scorebug gives you a lean. The next question is where to put your eyes, because you can’t watch 22 players at once, and if you try you’ll end up watching the ball like everyone else. The fix is a simple rule: **before each snap, pick one thing to watch, and watch only that until the play is over.** Choose it by the situation (your lean), and change it on each replay.

⁹NFL Football Operations, “NFL Next Gen Stats”: RFID tags in each player’s shoulder pads and 20–30 receivers in each stadium record location, speed and acceleration 10 times a second: <https://operations.nfl.com/gameday/technology/nfl-next-gen-stats/> ; Kevin Seifert, ESPN, “Inside Slant: NFL Next Gen Stats opens new doors” (Dec. 11, 2014), on the 2014 trial in 17 stadiums: https://www.espn.com/blog/nflnation/post/_/id/153569/inside-slant-nfl-next-gen-stats-opens-new-doors

¹⁰NFL Next Gen Stats defines average separation as the distance in yards between the receiver and the nearest defender at the time of the catch or incompletion (nflverse Next Gen Stats data dictionary, quoting the NGS definition: https://nflreadr.nflverse.com/articles/dictionary_nextgen_stats.html). Course calculation from nflverse `load_nextgen_stats(stat_type="receiving")`, 2025 regular season, the 120 qualifying receivers: mean 3.0 yards, range 1.9 to 4.6.

¹¹Course calculation from nflverse participation data (`time_to_throw`, FTN-sourced), 2025 regular season and playoffs: the median time to throw on dropbacks with a recorded time was 2.5 seconds (see also What a Play Really Is).

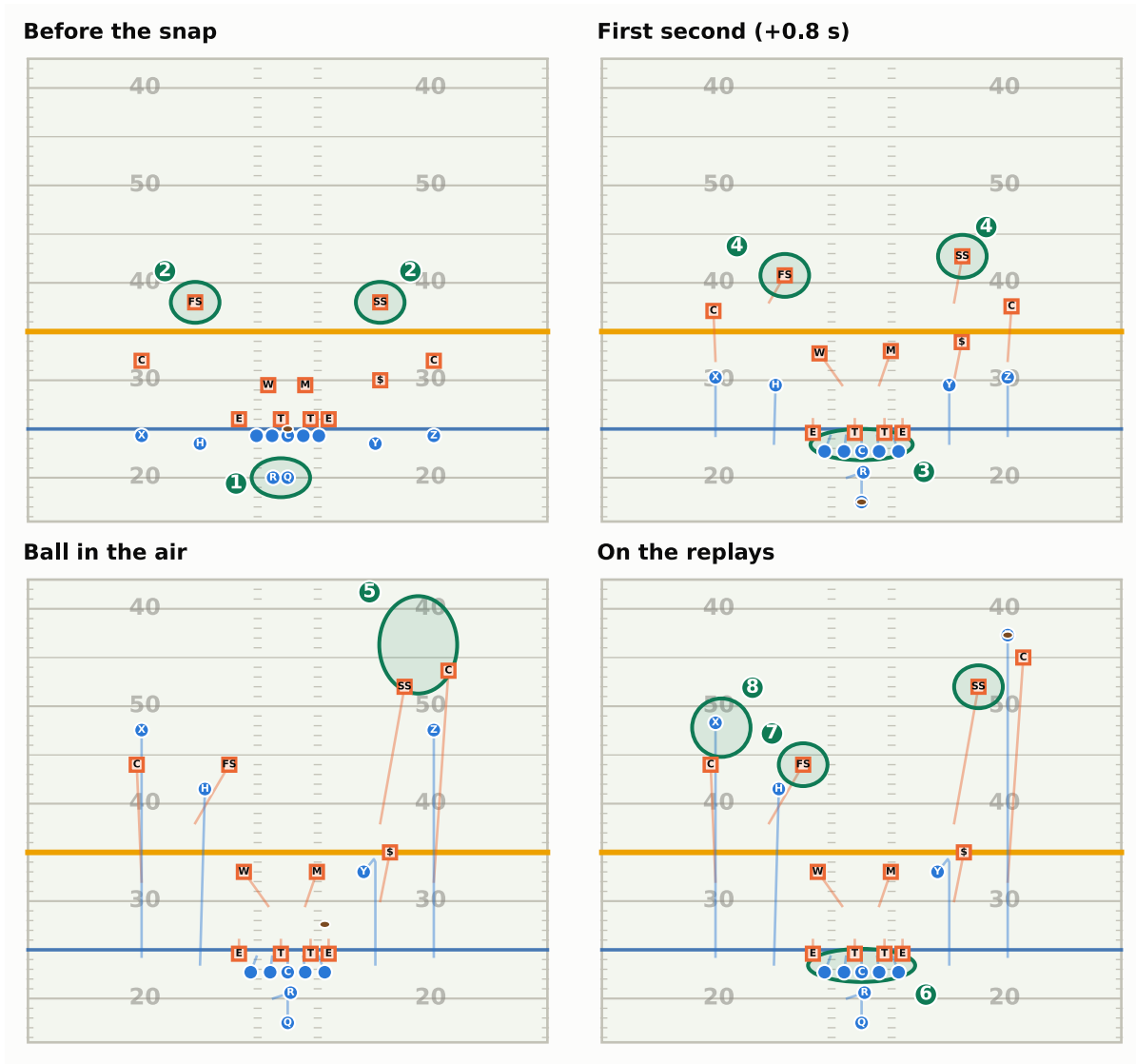


Figure 4: Where to look, phase by phase, on the same pass play as before. Green ovals and numbers are the order to look in. Before the snap: (1) the backfield (how deep the quarterback and back are, and which side the back is on), (2) the two safeties' depth. In the first second: (3) the linemen's first step (back = pass, forward = run) and (4) the safeties' first steps. With the ball in the air the camera does the work, so take one last look at (5) the catch point and who is closing on it. On the replays, take one group per replay: (6) the line, (7) the safeties, (8) the receiver who didn't get the ball.

Here is how to choose your one thing:

Table 2: Picking your one thing.

Your lean before the snap	Watch this one thing	Why it pays
Pass (third-and-long, trailing late, shotgun with no back)	The two safeties, from the snap	Where they go in the first second tells you the coverage and where the ball can go deep
Run (short yardage, ahead late, heavy formation)	One guard: forward or back, and which way	Linemen firing forward is a run; the guard's direction tells you where
Short yardage / goal line	The line of scrimmage itself: who moves forward	These plays are won by a yard of push, and the push shows up before the ball carrier does
No idea (first-and-10 in the middle of the field)	The offensive line's first step	It answers run or pass in under a second, which is the question you couldn't answer
Replays	A different group each time: line, then safeties, then the receiver who wasn't thrown to	Each replay angle is built for one of them (Table 1)

Why does narrowing your eyes help you see more? Because a football play is several smaller contests happening at once (the line against the rush, the receivers against their defenders, the quarterback against the safeties), and each one is readable only if you follow it from the start. A glance at the safeties after the ball is thrown tells you where they ended up; watching them from the snap tells you what they were *doing*, and that is what explains the play. The broadcast will show you the ball whether you watch it or not.

Tells: clues you can see before the snap

Players can't hide everything. A lineman about to fire forward stands a little differently from one about to step back; a running back who needs a running start lines up deeper; a defense that wants an extra man near the line has to put him there before the snap. Any such detail that leaks what's coming is a **tell**: a clue that shifts the odds, never a guarantee. Coaches hunt for their opponents' tells all week, and spend just as long hunting for their own, so they can break them (it's called self-scouting; see Constraint Theory and Sequencing). That arms race is why every tell in this section comes with a "usually."

Here are four to start your catalogue. The full catalogue, with linebackers, cornerbacks and the tight end, is in Watching Live.

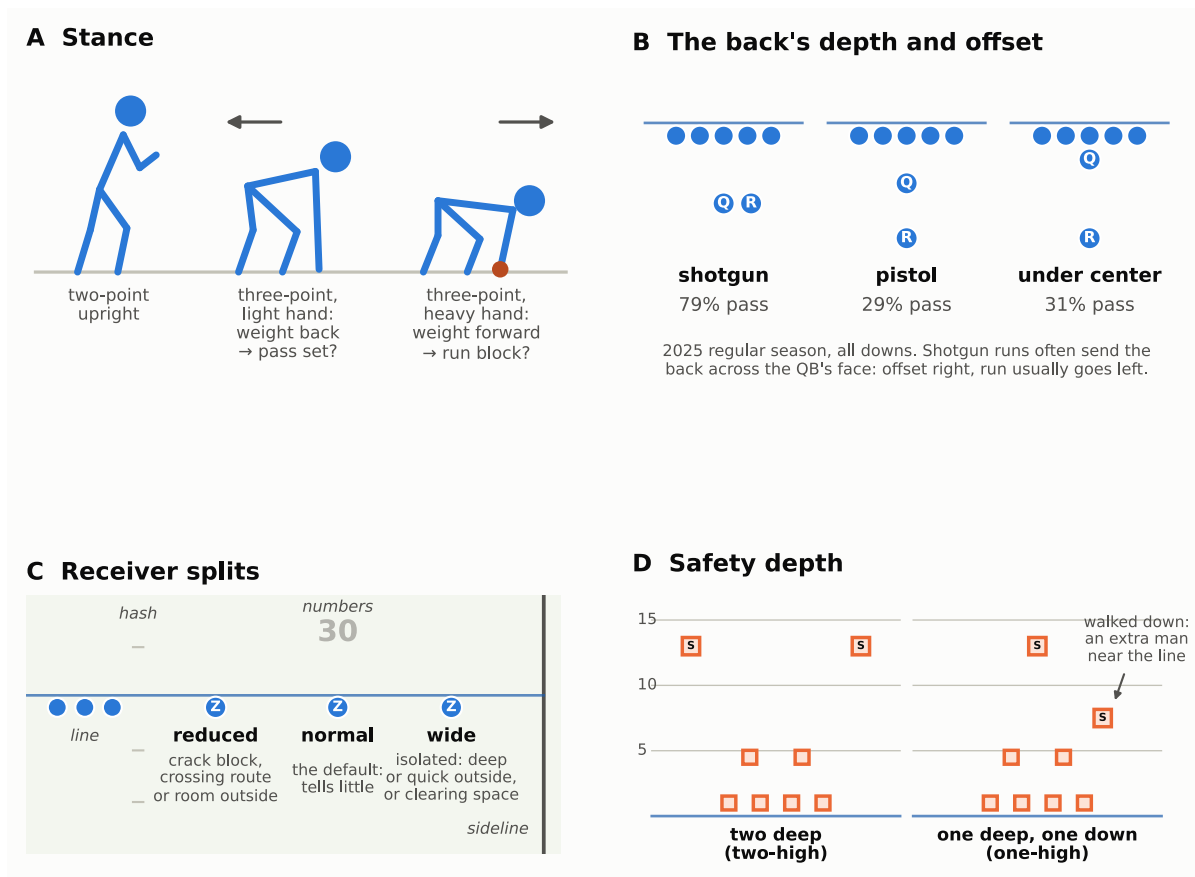


Figure 5: Tells starter card: four clues to check before the snap, each a lean, not a law. Stance: a lineman's weight on his hand usually means run, weight on his heels usually means pass. Backfield: in the 2025 regular season, offenses passed on 79% of snaps from the shotgun and about 30% from under center or the pistol (FTN charting via nflverse). Splits: where a receiver lines up, relative to the painted numbers, hints at his job. Safety depth: two safeties deep vs one deep with one walked down changes how many defenders are near the line.

Stance: where the weight is

A player's **stance** is how he stands just before the snap. In a **two-point stance** he is upright, with only his two feet on the ground; in a **three-point stance** one hand is also down (a four-point stance, both hands down, shows up at the goal line). Linemen on both sides mostly use three-point stances, because a hand on the ground lets you start low and drive forward. Many offensive linemen in shotgun-heavy offenses stand up in a two-point stance, especially on obvious passing downs, because a pass blocker's first step is backward and an upright start makes that quicker.

The tell is in the hand. A lineman with a **heavy hand** (also called a **heavy stance**) has his shoulders out over his down hand and a lot of his weight on it; sometimes you can see his knuckles whiten. He is coiled to go forward, which usually means a run block. A lineman whose hand barely touches the grass, hips back and weight on his heels, is ready to step back into a pass set (Pass Protection). Defensive linemen give the same tell in reverse: a rusher sitting back on his heels may be about to drop into coverage or play the run, not charge.

Why does a professional give this away? Because physics doesn't negotiate. A 320-pound man can't explode forward from his heels or backward from his fingertips, and a tenth of a second lost at the snap is a lost block. Good coaches teach a "balanced" stance that looks the same for run and pass, and the best linemen manage it, but under pressure (third-and-1, a loud stadium) the weight creeps to where the job is. The end-zone replay is the best angle for checking yourself; on the live shot you'll mostly catch it on the close-up of the line before the snap.

The running back: depth and offset

Where the running back lines up is a clue to both *whether* the play is a run and *which way* it goes. Three common setups:

- **Shotgun with the back beside the quarterback.** The quarterback stands about five yards behind the center (the shotgun) and the back stands next to him, *offset* to one side. This is mostly a passing look: in the 2025 regular season offenses threw on

79% of shotgun snaps.¹² When they do run from it, the most common runs send the back across the quarterback's face, so a back offset to the quarterback's right usually runs to the left (Zone Running shows why).

- **Pistol.** The quarterback is about four yards back with the back directly behind him, six or seven yards deep (pistol). The back's central spot hides the direction of the run, and the depth gives him a running start; teams ran on about 70% of pistol snaps in 2025.
- **Under center.** The quarterback takes the snap directly from the center (under center), and the back is usually six to seven yards deep. Also mostly a run look (about 69% runs in 2025), but this is the alignment the play fake is built for, as the film room below shows.

Depth matters within each. A back who creeps closer than usual may be about to block or run a quick route; one who sets deeper than usual wants room to read the blocks before he picks a hole.

Receiver splits: how far out they stand

A receiver's split is how far from the ball (or the nearest lineman) he lines up. The painted numbers are a handy ruler: most outside receivers line up near them. Departures from that default carry information, because a receiver chooses his split to make his job easier:

- A **reduced split** (well inside the numbers) puts him close to the formation. That suits a crack block (blocking a linebacker or safety from the outside on a run toward him), a route that crosses the field (the trip across is shorter), or, the other way around, a route that breaks *outside* and needs room to the sideline.
- A **wide split** (outside the numbers, near the sideline) isolates him. That often means a quick throw to him or a deep route along the sideline, or it simply means his job is to drag his defender out of the way.

Splits are a weaker clue than stance or the backfield, since a reduced split can mean three different things. They mainly tell you *where* to look after the snap. Remember too that the ball's position on the hash marks (The Game in Fifteen Minutes) changes what "normal" looks like: on the short side of the field, everything is squeezed.

Safety depth: one high or two

Find the safeties before every snap; if they are off the screen, look at the top of the frame and wait for the skycam replay. Their depth is the defense's biggest tell, because the safeties are the defense's flexible pieces. Two safeties deep, each 12 to 15 yards off the ball on his own side, is a two-high picture: the deep field is protected on both sides, and there are fewer defenders near the line to stop a run. One safety in the deep middle with the other walked down to seven or eight yards is a one-high picture: the defense has added a man near the line (in the box, the area between and just outside the offensive tackles), which helps against the run and makes extra pass rushers possible. A safety who walks down *late*, with only a few seconds on the play clock, is worth noting in particular: he has either seen something he wants to stop or he is trying to fool the quarterback. Defenses disguise this on purpose, and Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage teaches how to see through it.

How strong is each clue?

Stance and safety depth aren't in public data, but the quarterback's and back's alignment is, because charting services record it on every snap. That lets us see how much one clue is worth, team by team:

¹²Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play joined to FTN charting (`qb_location`), 2025 regular season, runs and dropbacks: shotgun 78.5% pass (20,104 snaps), under center 31.1% (11,035), pistol 29.3% (1,618).

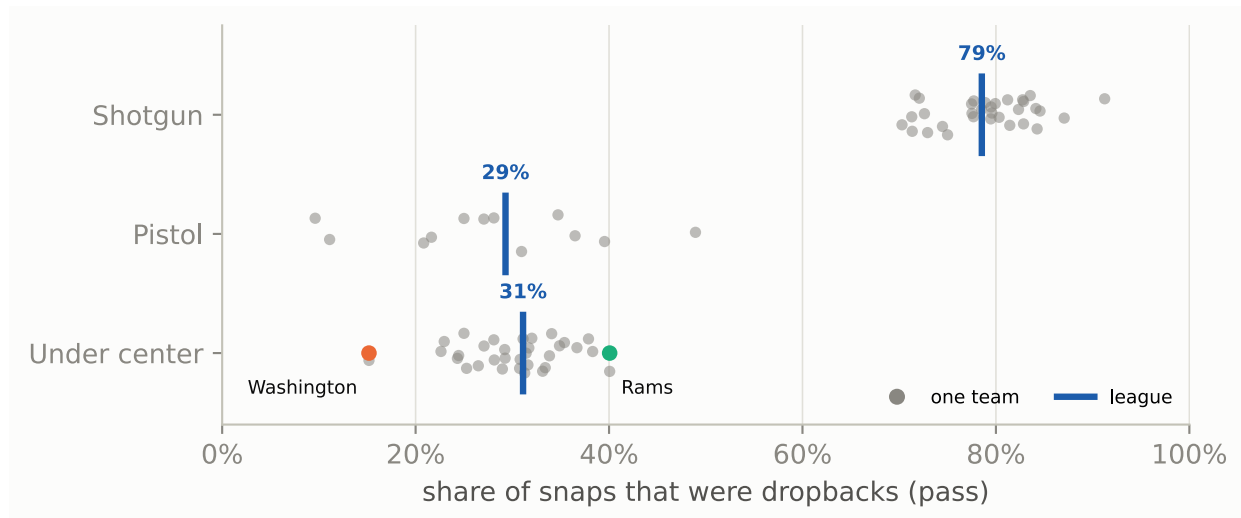


Figure 6: How often offenses passed from each quarterback alignment, 2025 regular season (each dot is one team; pistol shows teams with 40 or more pistol snaps). The alignment is a strong clue on average, about 79% pass from the shotgun against about 30% from under center or the pistol, but teams differ a lot: Washington passed on 15% of its under-center snaps, the Rams on 40%.

Source: nflverse play-by-play joined to FTN charting; runs and dropbacks only.

i Film room: Rams 2025 — when the tell is the bait

Sean McVay’s Rams lined up under center on 59% of their 2025 snaps, more than any other team, and threw from under center 40% of the time, also the most.¹³ That is not an accident. An under-center offense that runs well trains the defense to read “under center” as “run”; then it fakes the handoff and throws behind the linebackers who stepped up to stop it. That is play-action, the pass designed to look like a run, and it is the reason the tell exists *and* the reason it’s unreliable. League-wide in 2025, about 82% of passes thrown from under center used a play fake, against about 10% from the shotgun. (Matthew Stafford, the Rams’ quarterback, was the league’s MVP that season.¹⁴)

What to notice: when an under-center team is having a good day running, the play fake is coming. Watch the safeties on the snap after a big run. If one of them takes a step forward at the fake, that is the “bit on the play-action” moment from the opening of this chapter, and the skycam replay will show you the receiver running into the space he left.

🔥 Common misconception

“Under center means run.” On average, yes: in 2025 about seven in ten. But the 30% that are passes are the most dangerous ones, because they are built to exploit exactly that belief. Every tell in this chapter works the same way. A clue that is never wrong would be fixed by the coaches within a week; the ones that survive are the ones that are right *usually*, and the offense chooses when to make them wrong. So log your guess with a confidence, not a certainty.

The prediction log

You now have a lean from the scorebug and a few clues from the formation. The habit that turns those into a skill is writing them down. A **prediction log** is your running record of pre-snap calls: for each snap, the situation, your guess, how sure you were, the clue you leaned on, and what happened. You started a rough version in Downs, Distance, and Field Position, guessing run or pass from the down and distance alone and keeping a tally. That tally was your baseline. This is the formal log you’ll keep for the rest of the course.

Why write it down rather than just watch and nod? Three reasons.

¹³Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play joined to FTN charting, 2025 regular season: the Rams’ under-center share (59%) and under-center pass rate (40%) were the league’s highest; Washington’s under-center pass rate (15%) was the lowest. Play-action (`is_play_action`) was used on 82% of under-center dropbacks and 10% of shotgun dropbacks league-wide.

¹⁴NFL.com, “List of NFL Honors award winners from the 2025 NFL season”: <https://amp.nfl.com/news/list-of-nfl-honors-award-winners-from-2025-nfl-season>

1. **Memory flatters you.** After the play, the clue that pointed the right way seems obvious, and the guess you got wrong quietly disappears. On paper, it doesn't.
2. **It tells you which clues work.** If you note the clue behind each call, after a few games you can see whether "heavy hands" is making you right or wrong, for you, on the teams you watch.
3. **It makes improvement visible.** Reading a game gets better slowly. A number that moves from 62% to 70% over a season is the only reliable way to know it's happening.

Here is the paper version. A notebook page with these columns is all you need:

PREDICTION LOG • Game: _____ • Watching: offense of _____									
#	Qtr clock	Down & dist	Ball on	Score	Call	Conf.	Main clue	Result	✓/✗
1	1st 12:40	1st & 10	own 25	0-0	R	55%	under center, 2 TEs	R	✓
2	1st 12:02	2nd & 7	own 28	0-0	P	70%	shotgun on 2nd & long	P	✓
3	1st 11:20	3rd & 2	own 33	0-0	R	60%	heavy hands on the right	P	✗
4	1st 10:41	1st & 10	own 42	0-0	P	75%	shotgun, no back	P	✓
5	1st 9:58	2nd & 3	own 49	0-0	R	65%	under center, back at 7	R	✓
6	1st 9:20	1st & 10	opp 44	0-0	R	50%	nothing: coin flip	P	✗
Score so far: 4 of 6 = 67%. Baseline from 'down & distance only' (your 01-02 tally): ____%									

Figure 7: A paper prediction log, with six snaps filled in as an example. One line per snap. 'Call' is run (R) or pass (P); 'Conf.' is how sure you were (50% is a coin flip); 'Clue' is the one thing that decided it. Fill in 'Result' after the play, then tick or cross. The confidence column will matter later, when your log is scored as probabilities rather than hits and misses.

And here is the same log in pandas, for when you've typed a game's worth into a spreadsheet and saved it as a CSV. It's ten lines, and it answers the three questions above: how often you were right, how that compares to the simplest possible guesser, and which clues earned their keep.

```
import pandas as pd

log = pd.read_csv("prediction_log_game1.csv")      # one row per snap you called
log["hit"] = log["call"] == log["result"]         # True when your call was right

print(f"You: {log.hit.mean():.0%} right on {len(log)} snaps")
print(f"'Always guess pass' would have scored {(log.result == 'P').mean():.0%}")
print(log.groupby("down").hit.mean().round(2))    # where you read well
print(log.groupby("clue").hit.agg(["mean", "size"]).round(2)) # which clues earn their keep
```

```
You: 68% right on 34 snaps
'Always guess pass' would have scored 62%
down
1    0.59
2    0.82
3    0.67
Name: hit, dtype: float64
      mean  size
clue
alignment 0.83   12
safeties  0.50    4
```

situation	0.62	13
stance	0.60	5

The second line of output is the honest comparison. Guessing “pass” every single snap is right about 60% of the time in today’s NFL, so a 60% log hasn’t shown any reading at all. How much better can you do, and where does the improvement come from? Here is what simple rules would have scored over the 2025 season:

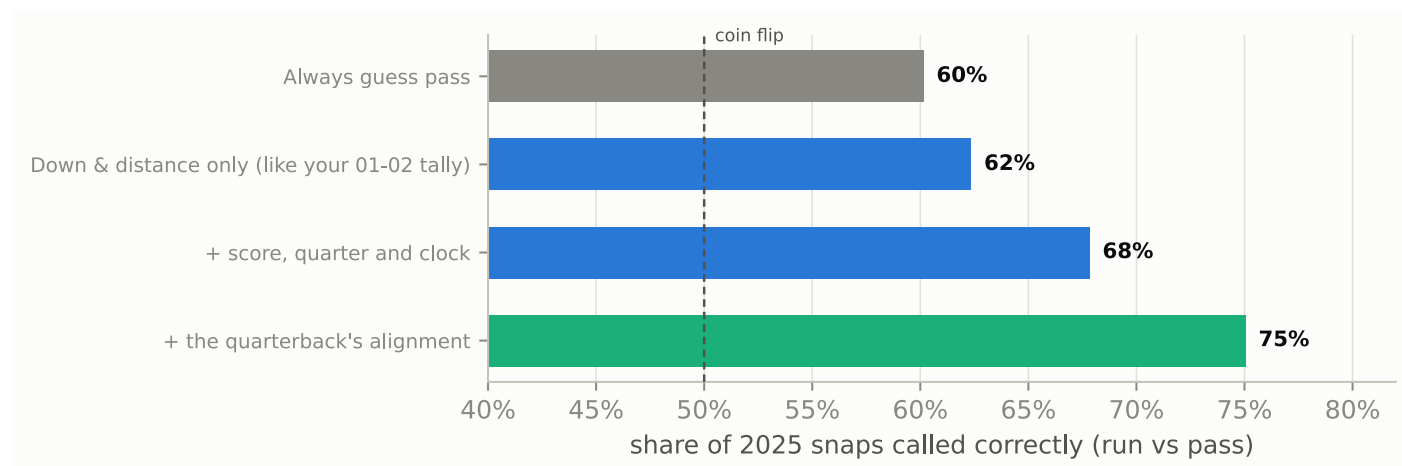


Figure 8: The bar to beat. Accuracy of simple run-or-pass guessers on every 2025 regular-season run and dropback (32,813 snaps). Each rule was learned from the 2024 season (for every combination of its inputs it guesses whichever was more common in 2024) and then scored on 2025, the way your own guesses are made before the fact. The situation on the scorebug gets you from 60% to about 68%; one glance at the quarterback’s alignment adds about seven points more. Source: nflverse play-by-play and FTN charting.

Three lessons hide in that chart.¹⁵ First, **down and distance alone barely beat “always pass.”** That’s because first-and-10, the most common situation by far, is close to a coin flip (about 50% pass in 2025), so a rule built only on the scorebug guesses “pass” there and gets half of them wrong. Second, the **score and the clock add more than the down does:** late in a half, and when a team is behind, the run-pass mix swings hard. Third, **one glance at the formation is worth almost as much as everything on the scorebug combined.** The coaches know this too; it is why the best offenses work so hard to run and pass from the same looks.

So the targets for your own log are clear. If you are under 60%, you’re doing worse than a guesser who never looks up. Around 65–68%, you’re reading the scorebug well. Above 70%, the formation and the tells are working for you. Don’t be surprised if your first log lands in the low 60s; that is what the scorebug alone is worth before you have practised reading it.

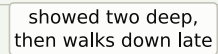
i Go deeper: why the confidence column?

“Right or wrong” throws away information. A 55% call that misses and a 90% call that misses are very different mistakes, and a good reader knows the difference before the snap. That’s why the log has a confidence column even though we score only hits and misses for now. When you reach Watching Live you’ll attach a confidence to every call, and Film Study: All-22, Charting a Game, and Scoring Yourself scores the season’s log the way forecasters are scored: whether your 70% calls come true about 70% of the time. Start filling it in now; it costs one number per snap.

What should you log beyond run or pass? For now, nothing. One prediction per snap, made before the snap, is plenty, and the discipline of making it *before* is the whole point. As the course goes on, each chapter’s drill adds a column: which side the run goes, which receiver gets the ball, whether the safeties will rotate, whether the defense will blitz. By the end your log will be a full pre-snap read.

¹⁵Course calculation; the code is in the figure’s folded cell. Snaps: 2024 and 2025 regular-season runs and dropbacks with a down recorded (nflverse play-by-play), joined to FTN charting for the quarterback’s alignment. Distance buckets 1–3, 4–6 and 7+ yards; score buckets trailing by 9+, trailing by 1–8, tied, leading by 1–8, leading by 9+; “clock” = the last two minutes of either half; “quarter” = fourth quarter or overtime. First-and-10 was 50% pass in 2025 (12,809 snaps); second-and-4 to –6 was 52% (2,623 snaps); second-and-5 to –7 from the shotgun was 76% (1,547 snaps).

For one half of one game, on every offensive snap of one team:



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💡 Predict the play 3: which clue wins?

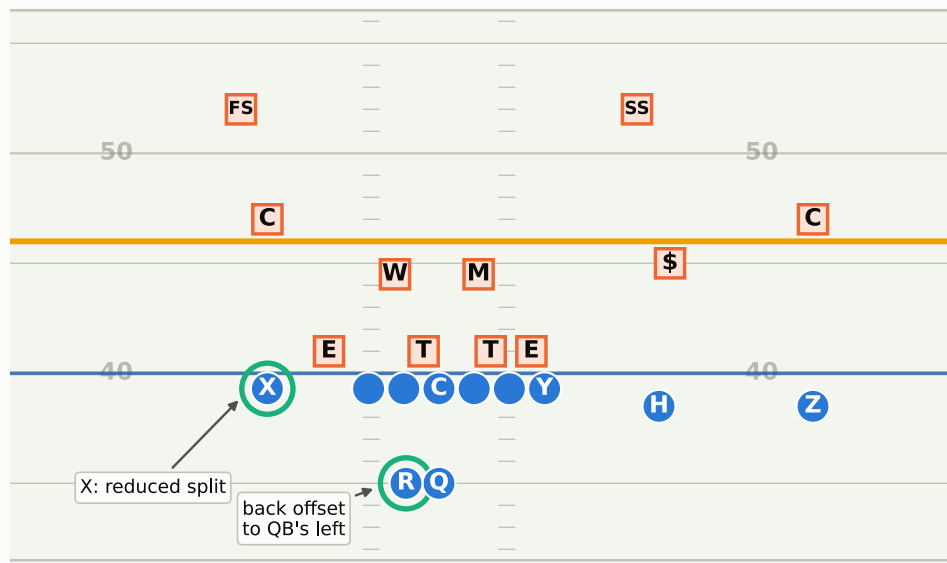


Figure 11: Second-and-6 at the offense's own 40, third quarter, ahead 14-10. Shotgun with three receivers to the right and the back offset to the quarterback's left. On the left, the lone receiver (X) has a reduced split, about four yards outside the left tackle instead of out near the numbers. The linemen are in two-point stances. Two safeties deep.

Four clues: second-and-6, shotgun, the back's offset, X's reduced split. Run or pass, and what does each clue tell you?

Answer 3 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

Takeaways

- **The broadcast is built for the ball.** The main sideline camera keeps the formation tight before the snap and chases the ball after it, so the safeties, the outside receivers and most of the coverage are off your screen when it matters. Replays exist to give them back: the end zone shows the line, the skycam shows the coverage, and the All-22 shows everyone.
- **Use the pause.** Read the scorebug in a fixed order (down and distance, field position, score, clock, timeouts) and turn it into a lean before the snap.
- **Watch one thing per snap and per replay,** chosen by your lean: the safeties when you expect a pass, a guard when you expect a run, a different group on each replay.
- **Tells are clues, not promises.** Stance, the back's depth and offset, receiver splits and safety depth all shift the odds, and the quarterback's alignment shifts them the most. The offense knows its tells too, and play-action lives on breaking them.
- **Keep a prediction log,** and score it against the bar: "always pass" gets about 60%, the scorebug about 68%, the scorebug plus the formation about 75%.

Connections

Builds on: The Pre-Snap Phase (the motion, shifts and checks you'll now see during the pause), What a Play Really Is (the forty seconds that the pause sits at the end of), and Downs, Distance, and Field Position (your baseline tally and the situation buckets).

Sets up: Personnel: Who's on the Field Before Anything Else adds the first column to your pre-snap read: who came onto the field. The rest of Part 2 adds formations and a first look at defense, and every later chapter adds a drill to the log. Further on: Win Probability and Decision Analysis and Tracking Data and the Big Data Bowl build the numbers glossed here; Watching Live completes the tells catalogue and the pre-snap checklist; and Film Study: All-22, Charting a Game, and Scoring Yourself turns the All-22 into a study routine and scores your season's log.

i Go deeper

- Pat Kirwan, *Take Your Eye Off the Ball* (2010; 2nd ed. 2015): the classic book on exactly this chapter's idea, by a former NFL coach and scout, with good sections on what to watch before the snap.
- Ron Jaworski with Greg Cosell and David Plaut, *The Games That Changed the Game* (2010): seven landmark games, explained by two people who spent careers watching coaches film.
- Chris B. Brown, *The Art of Smart Football* (2015): short essays on why plays are built the way they are, which tells you what to look for.
- NFL Next Gen Stats (nextgenstats.nfl.com): the league's own site for the tracking numbers broadcasts quote, with weekly leaderboards.

Answers to Predict the play

Answer 1.

Run, with high confidence, about 80–85%. Every clue agrees. Third-and-1 is the most run-heavy situation in football: in 2025, teams ran on about three in four third-and-1s, and from under center they ran on about 84%.¹⁶ Two tight ends and a fullback add blockers; the heavy hands say the line is coiled to go forward; the tailback's depth gives him a running start. The defense agrees with you, which is why nine defenders are crowded near the line.

Your one thing: the line of scrimmage, from the end-zone angle if you get it on the replay. Whose linemen move forward first and farther? On short yardage that yard of push decides the play before the ball carrier arrives.

Why not 100%? Because this is exactly the picture play-action is built for. With nine defenders charging the line and one safety deep, a fake handoff and a pass to a tight end sneaking out behind the linebackers is the classic counterpunch. A good log line here is "R, 85%, everything." If it turns out to be a play fake, that is not a bad prediction; it is the 15%.

Answer 2.

What changed: the defense went from two safeties deep to one, and put an extra defender next to the box. That is a one-high picture now, with seven defenders near the line between the slot receivers instead of six.

What it suggests: either the defense expects a run and wants another body to stop it, or it plans to send an extra pass rusher or play man-to-man coverage underneath. Either way, the deep part of the field now has only one safety, in the middle. The offense may respond: a quarterback who sees this can change the play at the line (The Pre-Snap Phase). And because he waited until the play clock was low, the defender may be bluffing: some safeties walk down and then race back at the snap, which is the disguise game of Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage.

How you'd know: on most broadcasts you'd see this only if the safety walks into the top of the frame, which is one more reason to keep an eye on the top edge of the screen during the pause. If you miss it live, the skycam replay will show the safeties' starting spots and their first steps. For your log this should *lower* your confidence in a pass on first down, not flip it: a defense that adds a man near the line is often inviting the throw.

Answer 3.

Pass, about 75%. Weigh the clues in order of strength, broad ones first:

1. **Second-and-6** on its own is a coin flip: about 52% pass in 2025 for second-and-medium.
2. **Shotgun** moves it a long way. In 2025, teams passed on 76% of their shotgun snaps on second-and-5 to -7. That is your call. (The two-point stances agree, but standing linemen are common in the shotgun, so they add little.)
3. **The back's offset** doesn't change run-or-pass much. It tells you *which way* a run would likely go (from the left, across the quarterback's face, to the right, toward the three receivers) and which side he would protect on a pass.
4. **X's reduced split** tells you about X, not about the whole play. Alone on the backside, in tight, he is set up for a route that breaks inside (a slant or a dig across the middle), or for a block if the run comes his way.

¹⁶Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play joined to FTN charting, 2025 regular season: third-and-1, 23% pass overall (853 snaps) and 16% pass from under center (525 snaps).

So: “P, 75%, shotgun on 2nd & medium.” Then pick your one thing: X and the cornerback over him, from the snap. If X breaks inside and the ball goes there, the reduced split was the tell. If the ball goes elsewhere, check on the replay whether X was open anyway. That is how small clues become reliable ones: by checking them, snap after snap, in your log.